English - UNIT 1_

Study copy from UNIT 1_.docx. Text and figures have been reflowed for reading. Page references refer to this PDF copy.

The Gift of the Magi

By O. Henry

“The Gift of the Magi” by O. Henry is a touching and timeless short story that explores the theme of love and sacrifice. The story revolves around a poor, young married couple, Jim and Della Young. Right before Christmas, they run into financial difficulties. As The Gift of the Magi progresses, both sell their most prized possession to pay for a gift for the other.

The story opens the day before Christmas with a young woman named Della sitting at home counting her savings. She and her husband Jim reside in a modestly equipped rented apartment. Jim was making more money when they initially moved in, but the pair has struggled and now lives in poverty. For many months, Della has been saving money after making grocery purchases. Despite her best efforts, she has not saved enough money, which makes her sad and frightened. She had hoped to use her funds to give Jim a nice present for Christmas. Realizing she won't have enough money to purchase Jim a Christmas present, Della begins to cry on her couch.

4. Della wipes her face when she stops crying and then stares out the window while lost in thought. She has an idea when she unexpectedly catches a sight of herself in the dark wall mirror. She spreads out her beautiful brown hair and takes a moment to admire it. Della's favourite treasure is her hair, which is known for its beauty. She puts on her old coat and hat and visits a shop that buys and sells hair. Madame Sofronie, the shop owner, agrees to cut and purchase Della's hair. Della spends the rest of the day going around the city looking for the perfect gift for Jim. His prized possession is a gold pocket watch that has been passed down through his family. She wants to buy him a nice chain to go with it, something special and rare. Eventually, she eventually finds the perfect platinum chain. It costs all the money she got from selling her hair, in addition to the majority of her savings. Della returns home feeling very excited to give Jim his gift.

When Della comes home, she makes every effort to arrange her new haircut. She worries that Jim won't like her anymore and will be upset. When Jim sees Della has cut her hair, his expression changes and he gets a strange look on his face. Not knowing what it means, Della approaches him and quickly explains that she sold her hair to buy him a Christmas present. In response, Jim hugs her and tells her he loves her no matter what her hair looks like. He then gives her a Christmas present: a set of tortoiseshell combs with jewels that she had once admired in a store window. Della loves the present, but she bursts into tears when she realizes she is unable to use Jim’s thoughtful gift.

As Jim comforts her, she reassures him her hair will grow back quickly. She then excitedly gives him the platinum watch chain. Jim laughs and reveals he sold his prized watch to pay for the combs. The narrator praises the couple for their unselfish acts of love and compares them to the three wise men who visited the newborn Jesus on the first Christmas Eve. He calls them even wiser than them.

They exchange gifts on the eve of Christmas. Jim gives Della a set of combs that she had seen in a store display and hoped would decorate her lovely hair. Jim receives a platinum chain from Della in exchange. Their gifts are evidence of their intense love and respect for one another's desires.

However, the narrative comes to a happy conclusion. As Jim and Della come to understand the actual worth of their abilities, their love for one another is evident. They realize that despite appearing to have been in vain, their sacrifices were a reflection of how much they loved each other. The best present of all is their

love, which they value more than anything else.

"The Gift of the Magi" does a wonderful job of encapsulating the genuine meaning of love, selflessness, and sacrifice. It serves as a reminder that while worldly belongings are transient, true love and the willingness to suffer for the sake of a loved one are invaluable. O.Henry's story continues to stir readers' hearts and serve as a powerful reminder of the eternal power of love and the spirit of giving.